

Servant of the People (And My Elephant)

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Introduction

In my personal ethics statement presentation, I explained how I have used Jonathan Haidt's idea of the elephant and the rider as a model for personal and ethical growth. Throughout the course, I found myself returning to his book, *The Righteous Mind: Why Good People Are Divided by Politics and Religion*, as a guide for tying together ethical frameworks and understanding how ethics can be applied to reality. Haidt's emphasis on actionable ethics and moral reasoning as a skill has resonated strongly with me. In this essay, I will further discuss my journey as an ethical person and how the course materials have helped me understand my values more deeply.

Revisiting My Values

The values I hold today have been shaped by my personality and the lessons I've learned through experience. Understanding the source of my values has helped me to lean on my natural strengths and to move toward my ideal ethical self. As discussed in my presentation, an important moment in my personal development came in 2018, when I began to re-examine my values as a 20-year old young man. At this time, I read Jonathan Haidt's *The Happiness Hypothesis: Finding Modern Truth in Ancient Wisdom*, where he first discusses the elephant and rider model. The ideas in this book helped me realize that values can evolve over time, especially when shaped by our personal experiences (Haidt, 2006).

Experiencing my parents' divorce, I believed that being kind meant keeping the peace at any cost. However, as I matured into a "recovering people pleaser", I discovered that true kindness often involves uncomfortable situations where doing the right thing is more important than maintaining harmony. For example, during my time in the Navy I learned that being kind often involves holding people accountable or admitting mistakes, rather than simply being

agreeable. Fortunately I was able to base this accountability on rules and regulations rather than morality which is a more difficult set of rules to interpret. I still struggle with confrontation and overpowering my old beliefs about who I am. But as a result of these experiences and practicing acting upon what I know is right, I feel more confident approaching hard problems with honesty and kindness.

My Favorite Ethical Theories

Virtue Ethics

According to Aristotle, happiness is achieved by becoming a person of virtue, someone with character, empathy, and integrity (Kaplan, 2022). I have always tried to be a “good” person and consciously worked to strengthen my virtue through habits and experiences. In the Navy, the structured environment helped me practice values like responsibility and respect. Simple tasks like keeping my workspace organized taught me self-discipline and reinforced the importance of attention to detail. These skills are now useful in many other parts of my life.

I have found that by practicing virtues in my daily life, I can improve my ability to align my actions with my core values. This approach to practice and repetition aligns with Haidt’s idea of “training the elephant.” Small, repeated actions can change our behavior over time by changing what we value (Haidt, 2012, p. 49). For example, I’ve become more comfortable admitting when I make a mistake or recognizing when I need help, which has made me more honest with myself and others. These habits have guided my journey of becoming the person I want to be.

Utilitarianism

Another ethical framework that reflects my values is utilitarianism, which emphasizes making decisions that do more good than harm (Kaplan, 2022). This idea is highly compatible

with my desire to make a positive impact on the people around me. For example, while working as an airframe mechanic, I was responsible for ensuring the safety of both my team and our aircraft. This often meant thinking ahead and addressing potential issues before they became critical problems.

Making decisions that benefit the majority is a large part of why I am pursuing a career in engineering. As an electrical engineer, I aim to design solutions that meet technical requirements while prioritizing the safety and well-being of the public. While I recognize that there are trade-offs, such as balancing safety precautions with cost or efficiency, utilitarianism offers a practical way to evaluate these decisions. By considering how my work will affect others, I can create designs that are both functional and beneficial to society.

Engineering Ethics

One of the most important lessons I have learned in this course is that ethical decisions are usually made in an environment of uncertainty. I know that it is okay to feel unsure about a decision as long as I take the time to think carefully. In the Navy, my role often involved identifying risks and addressing them before they became significant issues. This proactive approach reinforced the importance of thinking ahead and being flexible in response to challenges.

We also learned while discussing Giving Voice to Values (GVV) that some ethical decisions are not straightforward or easy to make. I did not connect with the pillars of GVV as much as I appreciated the stories used to relay the pillars as well as the tools and tactics the speakers used to make change in their organization. So I feel prepared to assess problems using an ethical framework, but I am nervous about ending up in a “rotten barrel” as seen in the Challenger case study. Or potentially worse, being pressured to break my values with the threat

of keeping my job like Suzanne Simard (Simard, 2021, p. 42). I think I can overcome the challenges by trusting my internal compass and raising ethical concerns.

But I do not necessarily want to be a hero. I know I will not be able to make change alone, I need and want trusted allies in my workplace. I feel capable of finding and forming strong relationships with like minded peers. I want to help be a voice of reason when my team comes across hard problems because I want my community to be safe.

Lessons Learned

Reflecting on my values and the concepts from this course has improved my understanding of how ethics guide both my personal and professional life. Frameworks like virtue ethics and utilitarianism are tools for evaluating decisions. Haidt's works have been impactful for me outside the scope of this course, but the reminder of the elephant and the rider was useful for me in my reflection. It has been a reminder that moral and ethical growth is incremental and made by practice, not perfection. I want to continue to improve my reasoning and emotional responses to navigate ethical challenges.

As I continue my studies and career, I want to stay committed to being honest, kind, and thoughtful in all aspects of my life. These values are not just ideas, they were made from my actions and personal experiences. My values will continue to shape who I am and what decisions I make. I am determined to become an engineer who not only solves problems but also considers the ethical implications of my professional decisions and how they will impact others.

References

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